Exhibit Name: **Date:**

Evaluator: **Role:**

Observation Type: ☐ **Free Play** ☐ **Programmed** ☐ **Mixed**

Instructions: *This checklist supports observation-based evaluation of museum exhibits using Universal Design principles. Each exhibit is to be observed for approximately 10 - 15 minutes per session, ideally across at least two different time points when feasible (for example, varying crowd levels). During observation, the reviewer should focus on observable environmental and design features, as well as patterns of interaction between children, caregivers, and the exhibit itself. The goal is not to evaluate individual children, but to assess how the exhibit functions as a system. For each criterion, reviewers may check the box if the exhibit meets the item. When a criterion is more nuanced, reviewers may instead use the* ***optional*** *scale by marking Present, Partially Present, Not Present, or Not Applicable. Items marked as Present or Partially Present reflect stronger alignment with Universal Design principles. This tool is descriptive and not intended to generate a score.*

General Notes:

Principle 1: Equitable Use
The exhibit is usable, appealing, and inclusive to children with diverse abilities.

☐ The exhibit includes opportunities for physically challenging play (e.g., climbing, crawling, stairs) without making these the only means of engaging with the core experience
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Children using mobility aids (e.g., wheelchairs, walkers) can independently approach, reach, and use the main interactive components of the exhibit.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ All children can engage in the same core activity without requiring a separate version.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ The exhibit provides key information through more than one sensory modality (e.g., visual, auditory, tactile).

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

Notes:

Principle 2: Flexibility in Use
The exhibit accommodates a wide range of preferences, abilities, and play styles.

☐ The exhibit allows for children to engage in more than one way (e.g., observing, physically interacting, moving around, or imaginative or pretend play).
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Children can choose how long and how intensely to engage with the activity.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ The exhibit supports independent engagement and cooperative play without requiring adult mediation
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Materials or components can be used in more than one way (not a single "right" outcome).
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ The exhibit can be used by children at different developmental stages and abilities without modification.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

Notes:

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Principle 3: Simple and Intuitive Use
Use of the exhibit is easy to understand regardless of experience, language, or cognitive ability.

☐ The purpose of the exhibit is clear without adult explanation
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ The exhibit's design makes it clear where and how children can begin interacting without adult instruction.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Children can understand how to engage with the exhibit without needing to read or requiring demonstration. If text is used intentionally, it is clearly supported by pictures, symbols, or modeling.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Children can successfully engage through trial and error.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

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Principle 4: Perceptible Information
The exhibit communicates necessary information effectively to users with different sensory abilities and preferences.

☐ Visual information (e.g., signage, symbols, labels, graphics) is clearly distinguishable from its background and visible across lighting conditions, heights, and viewing distances within the exhibit.

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Audio elements are clear and not overwhelming or startling.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Important cues (e.g., start/stop, cause-and-effect) are communicated through more than one sensory modality.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Signage or symbols are age-appropriate and easily interpreted
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Tactile features (e.g., textures, raised elements, manipulatives) provide functional information or feedback that supports interaction.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ The exhibit provides at least one non-visual way to perceive play-related information (e.g., through touch or movement).
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

Notes:
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Principle 5: Tolerance for Error
The exhibit minimizes hazards and supports exploration without fear of "doing it wrong."

☐ Children can explore freely without risk of injury from misuse
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

☐ There is no single failure point that stops engagement, or if present includes an opportunity to go back.

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

☐ Mistakes lead to learning opportunities rather than frustration.

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

☐ The exhibit is durable and forgiving of rough or unexpected use.

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

☐ Clear boundaries exist where safety is a concern (e.g., edges, moving parts).

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

Notes:

Principle 6: Low Physical Effort

The exhibit supports purposeful physical challenge while allowing children to regulate effort and participation.

☐ Physical effort required is intentional and aligned with the play or learning goal.

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

☐ Children can modulate their level of physical effort (e.g., pace, duration, intensity).

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

☐ Physically demanding elements are optional or paired with lower-effort ways to engage.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Controls or manipulatives do not require excessive strength beyond the intended challenge.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Opportunities to pause, rest, or observe are naturally available within the play space.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

Notes:

Principle 7: Size and Space for Approach and Use
Appropriate space is provided for approach, reach, manipulation, and use.

☐ Clear pathways allow children and caregivers to approach without congestion
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ A clear turning space (approximately 60 inches in diameter or equivalent) is available to allow individuals using mobility aids to turn or reposition independently.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Interactive components are within reachable heights for a range of users.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ Multiple children can engage without crowding.
(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable
Comments:

☐ The space supports adult participation in play.

(optional) ☐ Present ☐ Partially Present ☐ Not Present ☐ Not Applicable

Comments:

Notes:

Disclaimer: This tool is not intended to serve as a comprehensive or standardized measure of Universal Design. It was developed for a capstone project within the Children's Museum in Oak Lawn and reflects the scope of that work. Use beyond this context should be considered carefully and may require modification with permission.

This tool was created by Feba Elayadom for the Children's Museum in Oak Lawn as a partial requirement for a clinical doctoral degree for the Department of Occupational Therapy at University of Illinois Chicago, 2026